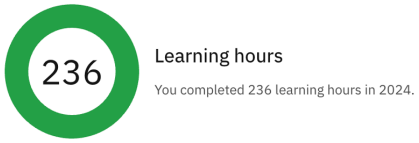
# Degree Apprenticeship Project Plan

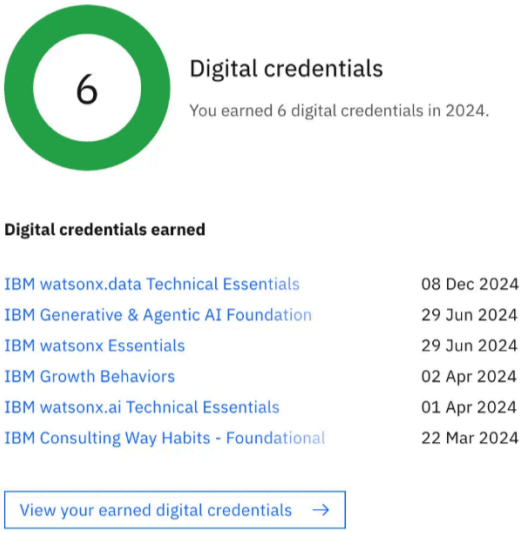
*Rio Kandekore - Environment Manager at IBM*

## 🧩 Project Context

IBM is a multinational technology company who specialise in hybrid cloud, artificial intelligence, and consulting services with our primary goal of bringing success to our clients and partners. (IBM,2025) IBM create partnerships through collaborative agreements between multiple organisations that work together to achieve specific goals while maintaining allowing them to maintain their independence. (Piseddu, 2024) An example of this strategy is IBM's partnering with AWS. We insert our consultants, values and expertises into AWS in order to advise, design and build business innovation that matters. (IBM,2025) Exercising these values resulting in being nominated and awarded the Client and Partner Success Award for my expertise through a Production Deployment Go Live.

*Image from IBM Recognition Center: "Client and Partner Success Award."*




*Images from IBM YourLearning Platform: "Achieved Top 7% Champion Learner Gold through continuous learning achieved 6 digital credentials focusing on Consulting Habits and Growth Behaviours."*

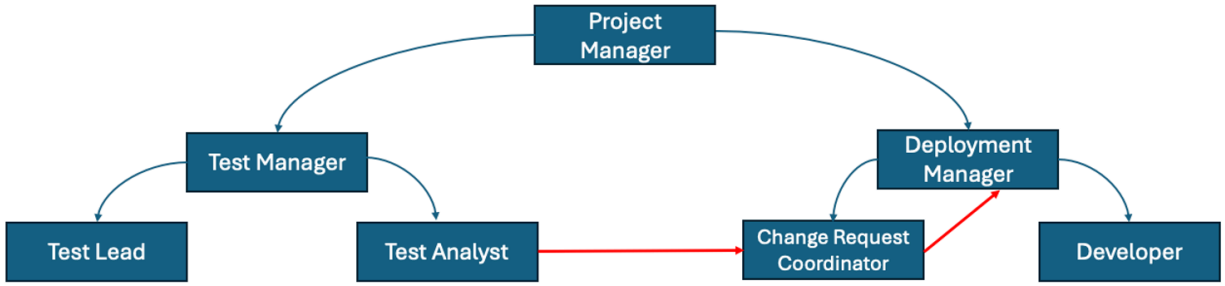



*Image created by Rio Kandekore: "Team Dynamic and Career Progression from Test Analyst, to Change Request Coordinator to Deployment Management."*

I initially joined IBM as a Software Tester through the Foundation Apprenticeship program in 2021. Upon completion, I specialised in Workflow Testing and Automation where I was responsible for writing and executing manual test scripts, finding and logging defects, and presenting my findings back to stakeholders through demo's and presentations.

Using my previous experience as a tester helped me succeed early into my role as a Deployment Manager, where I now work closely with the client to ensure that the appropriate Quality Assurance requirements are in place to provide a successful Route to Live delivery process.  An example of this would be the use of Runbook reviews after each Dress Rehearsals prior to Production Go Live. These test results are reviewed to ensure that the dress rehearsals orchestrated by the developers have met the needs of the requirements to move onto the next phase of the deployment process. (PMI, 2021, p. 79)

## Belbin Assessments

As part of understanding my approach to working within teams, I completed the Belbin Team Roles assessment. My strongest roles were **Implementer (11)** and **Team Worker (10)**, with **Complete Finisher (9)** as a supporting role. As an implementer, I can convert ideas into practical actions. An example of this would be innovating the Change Request process from Outlook to Jira for better accessibility to the wider business. As a team worker, I can confidently use my versatility to complete tasks within a team. As a case in point, using my testing knowledge from my previous role, I can communicate differ perspectives in meetings with stakeholders to give test solutions to deployment problems. With the Complete Finisher, I ensure Quality Assurance is at a high standard, specifically with extensive checks provided to documentation prior to creating the change requests. (Belbin, NA)

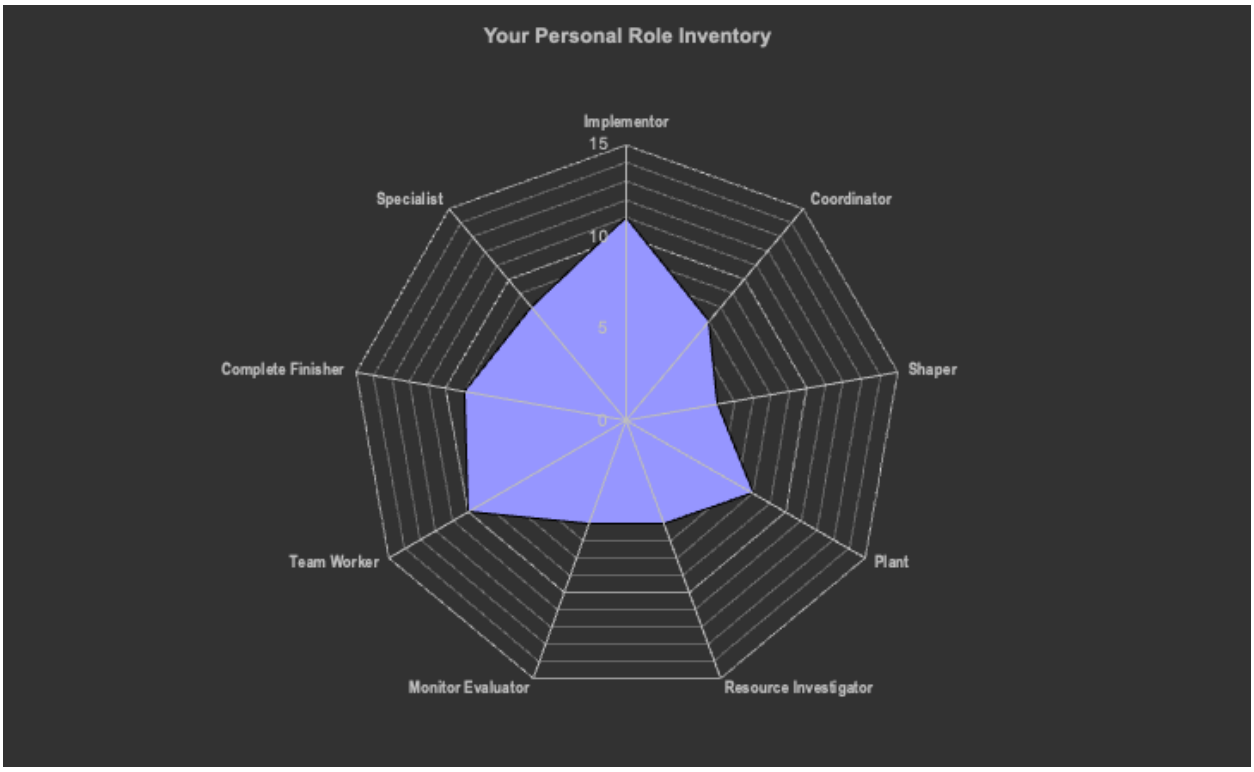



*Image from Belbin test from lecture PowerPoint: "My results after taking the Belbin assessment."*

## High-Performing Teams

Following my Belbin Results, the success I contribute to comes from a high performing team that is built on having a shared understanding. My colleague who supports me in change management also shares the same career progression of having testing experience which allows us to have a shared understanding on providing Quality Assurance to the Route to Live process as discussed in High Performing Project Teams. (PMI ,2021, p 22)

## Agile DSUMs

Linking back with working within a High performing team, Integrating Daily Stand Up Meetings (DSUM) has enhanced our collaboration between colleagues to across the different roles and has encourage more diverse ideas. Our calls include testers, architects, software engineers and project managers. As the whole team have busy schedules, integrating this call at the start of the day can provide a

quick and efficient way of understanding on what each participent is focusing on which helps us achieve our tasks easier. (Furman, 2015, p 378)

## Kanban board

For Kanban, our team use Jira to track the progress of tasks throughout the business. Using a Kanban Board has enforced prioritisation and rationalises the workload to make sure commitments are made to the tasks that are higher priority. (Ellis, 2020, p 410). We have also found success in improving traceability to defects across boards. This has been crucial as defects and issues are crucial information in our Change Requests. Below is a representation of a Kanban board for Change requests and deployment tasks for the Route to Live process.

| Name | Assign | Multi-select | Status | Tags | tag |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Untitled | | | In progress | | |
| CR Route to Live Environment 3 | | | In progress | | |
| Change Request Route to Live Environment 1 | | | Done | | |
| Change Request Route to Live Environment 2 | | | Done | | |
| Untitled | | | Not started | | |
| Untitled | | | Not started | | |
| Pre-Prod Change Request | | | Not started | | Approved |

| Name | Assign | Multi-select | Status | Tags | tag |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Environment 1 Deployment | | | Not started | | Done |
| Dress Rehearsal 1 Deployment | | | Not started | | Done |
| Dress Rehearsal 2 Deployment | | | Not started | | Approved |
| Untitled | | | Not started | | |
| Remote Desktop allocation for Pre-Prod | | | In progress | | In progress |
| Environment 1 Change Request | | | Not started | | Done |
| Production Go Live Deployment | R Rio Kandekore | | Not started | | Not started |
| Fix Defect RTL | R Rio Kandekore | | Not started | | Not started |
| Post Production Defect Fixes | | | Not started | | Backlog |

## Tuckman's Model

Following the use of this Kanban Model, the below image discusses the Tuckman Model has been evident in resolving a conflict with stakeholders which resulted in an improved process for approving Change Requests. Tuckman (1978)

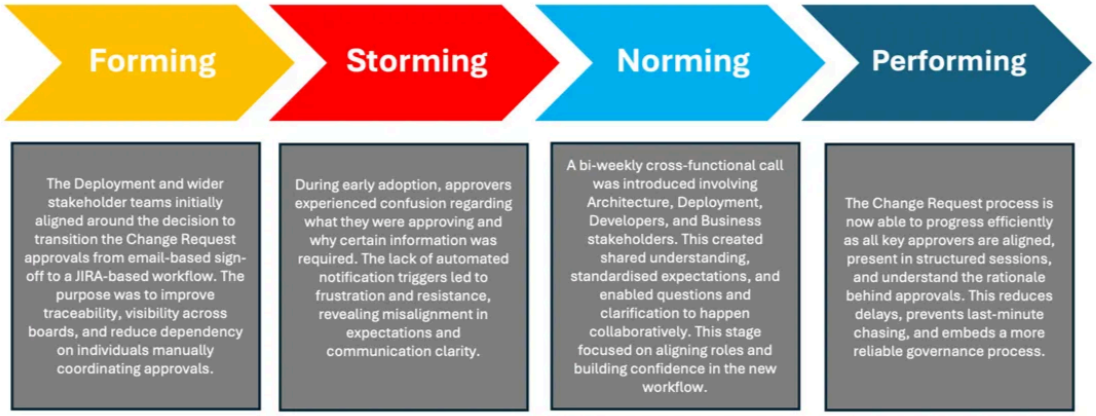



*Image created by Rio Kandekore:* "Tuckman's Model discussing overcoming conflict with a new Change Request process to obtain approvals."

# 🗓️ Project Management Tools and Methodologies

## Contractual Agreements

The use of contractual agreements such as a off the job hours requirements, KSBs allow me to have attainable targets to hit each year. As described in (Skills England, 2023) , my degree apprenticeship is split over 4 years with the objective to develop a broad set of skills across the whole Digital and Technology landscape. Following these contractual agreements, this will enable me to deliver the expected deliverables and outcomes that have been addressed in the Success Criteria. (PMI, 2021, p. 69)

attachment:96593751-9853-4a8c-976a-2900d238a2b3:ITC_KSB_Themes.pdf

*PDF from Manchester Metropolitan University: "KSB Documentation of the Key themes and KSB's for my apprenticeship."*

## Year 1 and Year 2 Skill Scans

## Project Plan

In the image below, I took this initial Skills Scan before I started my first year in order to understand the KSB gaps I had which gave me an overview of the things I needed to work on.

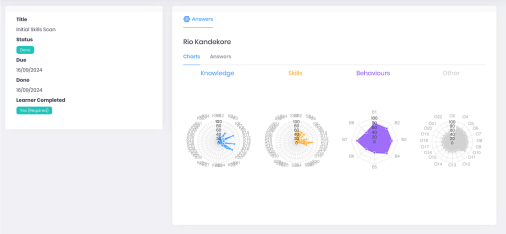



*Image from Smart Assessor: "Year 1 Skill Scan."*

Following the completion of my first year, I saw an overall improvement in all three areas of the Knowledge, Skills and Behaviours. With successfully completing my first year of university, I have completed Phase 1 within my Project Timeline.

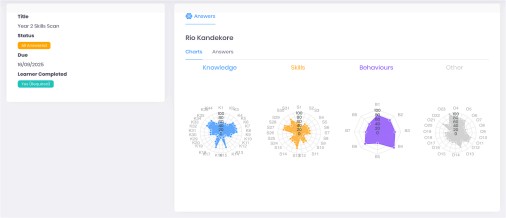



*Image from Smart Assessor: "Year 2 Skill Scan."*

| | |
|---|---|
| Project Summary | This project outlines my four-year Degree Apprenticeship journey at IBM, structured as a professional development project. It combines academic progression, industry experience, and personal growth to deliver both technical and business outcomes. The project aims to demonstrate the application of project management principles across education, work-based learning, and self-development initiatives. |
| Success Criteria | Obtain a first from my degree from university<br>Obtain a Distinction from my Apprenticeship at IBM<br>Become a more versatile apprentice (business-minded/technical)<br>Complete portfolio evidence aligned with Knowledge, Skills, and Behaviours (KSBs). |
| Scope of Work | My scope of work will consist of a blend between hands-on industry experience, University learning and self-development. Events such as networking socials, public speaking and apprenticeship communities. |
| Key Deliverables | Completion of BSc (Hons) Digital & Technology Solutions degree (First Class target)<br>Completion of IBM Apprenticeship with Distinction<br>Delivery of a personal and professional portfolio demonstrating technical, business, and leadership skills<br>Achievement of AWS and related certifications that align with IBM's vision<br>Successful transition into a technical or hybrid role (e.g., Cloud, Data, or AI)<br>Reflective report showcasing continuous learning, self-awareness, and risk mitigation throughout the apprenticeship lifecycle |
| Project Timeline | **Estimated Duration: 4 years (42.5 months)**<br><br>**Phase 1 - September 2024 - September 2025:**<br>Complete First Year of university (Level 4)<br>Move from testing to deployment to open up new opportunities<br>**Phase 2 - September 2025 - September 2026:**<br>Complete Second Year of university<br>Begin to Upskill (Courses, building relationships with seniors)<br>Portfolio work - Meet KSBs themes (Core Concepts)<br>**Phase 3 - September 2026 - September 2027:**<br>Complete Third Year of university<br>Land a technical role within Data Science/DevOps at IBM<br>Portfolio work - Meet KSBs themes (Technical Solutions /Underlying principles, and innovation and response)<br>**Phase 4 - September 2027 - June 2028:**<br>Complete final year of university with a First Grade<br>Complete my Apprenticeship with a Distinction Grade<br>Use new role to diversify EPA Portfolio<br>Portfolio work - Meet KSBs themes (Leading and working together, and Legal ethical landscapes) |

*Image created by Rio Kandekore: "Project Plan with the Project Summary, Success Criteria, Scope of work, Key deliverables and Project Timeline broken down into 4 phases in order to reach my targets."*

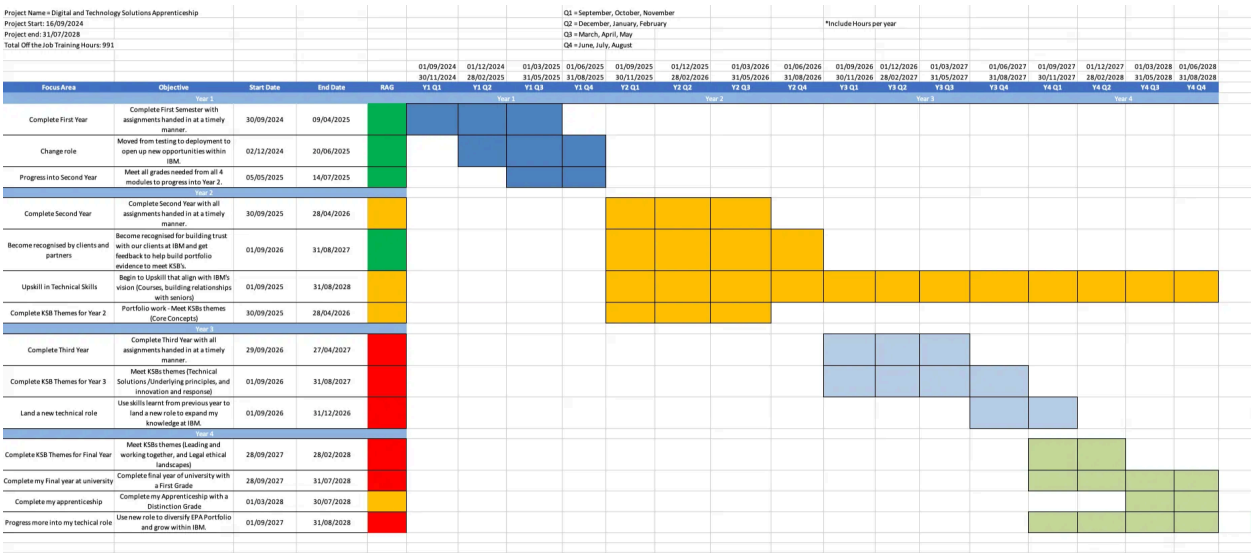



*Image created by Rio Kandekore: "4 Year Gaant Chart based on contracts, KSB's, personal development and Project Plan."*

## 👥 Stakeholder Management

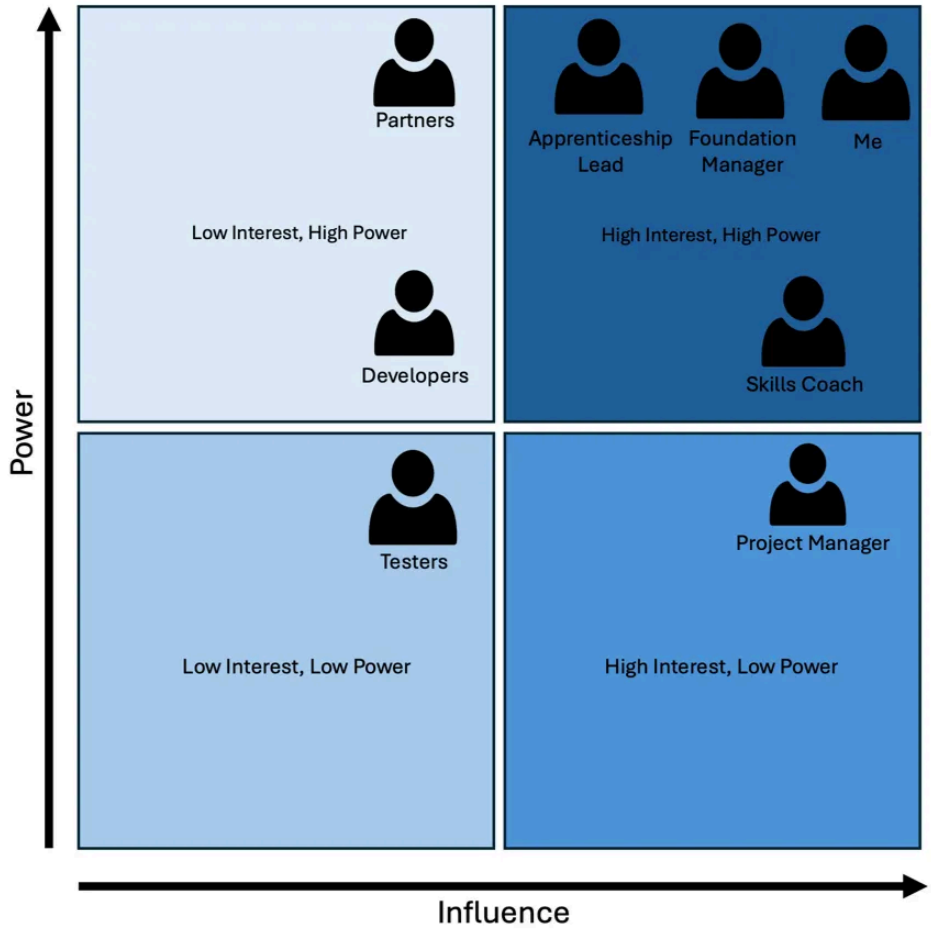



*Image created by Rio Kandekore: "Mendelow's Matrix map to determine Stakeholder Power and Influence." (Mendelow, 1981)*

The power and influence chart shows the power and interest my chosen stakeholders have in my apprenticeship.

**High Power, High interest -** Stakeholders who hold the most influence in my apprenticeship

**High Power, Low interest -** Assign the work that will be used as evidence for my EPA portfolio, however isn't directly involved with my apprenticeship.

**Low Power, High interest -** These stakeholders do not directly have power but their influence/mentorship can provide growth within my role.

**Low Power, Low interest -** only require communication if apprenticeship meetings clash with project meetings.

After identifying my stakeholder's power and influence, I created this RACI chart to show stakeholders who are responsible, accountable, consulted, or informed and are associated with the project activities, contractual agreements, and deliverables during my Degree Apprenticeship. (PMI, 2021, pg 189)

| RACI Chart | Stakeholders | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Activity | Rio (Apprentice) | Elina (Skills Coach) | Charlotte (Line Manager) | Andy (Project Manager) |
| Attend University and complete assignments | R | A | C | I |
| Setting up meetings to monitor progress | A | R | R | I |
| Complete OTJ Hours, Submit Timesheets and complete Quarterly/ Yearly reviews on time | R | A | A | I |
| Gather portfolio evidence for EPA | R | A | A | I |
| Receive feedback from project connections | R | I | I | A |
| Continue to upskill to stay up to date with IBM's vision | R | I | I | I |
| R = Responsible A = accountable C = consult I = Inform | | | | |

*Image created by Rio Kandekore: "RACI chart to demonstrate which stakeholders hold the most influence in my apprenticeship."*

| Role | Thinking Style | Power | Influence | Communication Plan | Incentives |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Apprenticeship lead | Practical | High | High | Events<br>Celebrations<br>Apprentice Inititives | My success on the apprenticeship scheme benefits this stakeholder as it builds IBM's apprenticeship reputation, which upholds with IBM winning Apprenticeship of the Year 2024. |
| Foundation Manager | Experimental | High | High | Quarterly Reviews<br>Mid Year Reviews<br>End of year Reviews | Better reputation within the role. Making sure I stay ontop of logging my OTJ Hours, Timesheets, and punctuality being on point will help not flag anything up on my manager's side. |
| Skills Coach | Relational | High | High | Quarterly Reviews | My success on the apprenticeship scheme benefits this stakeholder as it builds MMU's apprenticeship reputation. |
| Project Manager | Experimental | Medium | High | DSUMs<br>1-2-1 calls<br>End of day calls | Builds trust with workload, helps me to build more evidence for my apprenticeship portfolio. |
| Partner | Practical | High | Medium | Deployment Weekends | Partners benefit business wise when I succeed when I'm able to manage the Route to Live process with ease. This is something I was recognised with an award for. |
| Developer | Analytical | Medium | Medium | Deployment Standups | Succeeding in my role boosts productivity for the developers, my managerial skills will help manage the Route to Live process for deployment run much smoother. |
| Tester | Experimental | Low | Medium | Testing Standups | Succeeding in my role boosts productivity for the testers my managerial skills will help manage the testing phase run much smoother. |

*Image created by Rio Kandekore during Week 5 Stakeholder Management Lecture: "Stakeholder Map to demonstrate which stakeholders hold the most influence in my apprenticeship."*

(Offord-Woolley, 2024)

## ⚠️ Risk Management Planning

In my risk assessment plan, I identified my personal well-being and workload as the highest inherent risk to my apprenticeship. As identified in my Mendelow Matrix map, I have the most power and influence for my apprenticeship of all of my stakeholders. Engaging with relevant stakeholders alongside having my Risk Assessment Plan to review and understand my risks will help me mitigate the probability and impacts long term. (PMI 2021, p 54)

| Risk Matrix | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Insignificant A | Minor B | Significant C | Major D | Severe E |
| Almost Certain 5 | Medium | High | Very High | Extreme | Extreme |
| Likely 4 | Medium | Medium | High | Very High | Extreme |
| Moderate 3 | Low | Medium | Medium | High | Very High |
| Unlikely 2 | Very Low | Low | Medium | Medium | High |
| Rare 1 | Very Low | Very Low | Low | Medium | Medium |

*Image created by Rio Kandekore: "Risk Matrix to measure the probability and impacts of my risks."*

| Rio Kandekore - Risk Assessment Plan | | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | Inherent Risk | | | | Residual Risk | | |
| Risk | Risk Description | Risk Owner | Probability | Impact | Risk Rating | Mitigation | Mitigation Owner | Residual Probability | Residual impact | Residual Risk |
| Time Management | Balancing university deadlines, IBM work, and personal commitments. | Rio | High | Extreme | 5E | Implement the use of planning tools such as Notion Calenders, Time-Blocking and prioritise tasks weekly. Communicate early with mentors or line managers about deadlines. | Rio | Low | Medium | 2C |
| Skill Gap/ Knowledge | Not keeping up with IBM's vision with Cloud, Data and AI for future roles and opportunities. | Rio | Low | High | 3D | Put aside 30 minutes a day to contribute to any external learning to ensure I build my knowledge. This also ties in with making sure I don't burnout. | Rio | Low | Medium | 2D |
| Data Security and compliant risks | Handling confidential client data during projects could risk breaches or non-compliance if not managed correctly. | Rio | Medium | Extreme | 4E | Follow IBM data governance courses, use secure systems, and never store client data locally. | Rio | Low | High | 2B |
| Personal Wellbeing and Workload | Managing multiple responsibilities (university, IBM projects, side learning) can cause burnout or reduced performance. | Rio | High | Extreme | 5E | Maintain healthy routines such as exercise, sleep and nutrition. Using MMU wellbeing support if needed, and discuss workload balance with managers or mentors if I begin to struggle. | Rio | Low | Medium | 2C |
| Miscommunication bewteen stakeholders | Miscommunication bewteen stakeholders with things such as OTJ hours, Timesheets and issues on my project could cause issues. | Rio | Medium | Very High | 4D | Making sure that if there is an issue to directly consult with my stakeholders as soon as possible. This also helps with maintaining a great reputation. | Rio | Low | Medium | 2C |

*Image created by Rio Kandekore:* “My results after taking the Belbin assessment.”

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# 🪞 Reflection (Gibbs’ Reflective Cycle)

## Description

After moving to Manchester for university, I struggled to get used to living on my own, starting university and adjusting to my new role. I went from contributing to food shopping at my moms house to paying rent with utilities, as well as making sure I was maintaining a clean space along with cooking. Before moving, I was a young carer for my older brother in Birmingham so there was an element of guilt when I moved out as I couldn't be present to help my mom.

## Feelings

I found this change extremely difficult to the point where I burnt out. Tasks such as getting out of bed, cooking and cleaning felt like massive challenges. Failing one of my assignments also increased my anxiety when it came to assignments and exams. I turned to services such as the university counselling for external help. Initially, I felt quite uncomfortable speaking to my Skills Coach , however she was very welcoming which related to their relational thinking style from my stakeholder map.  I also felt it was also important to communicate the reason why my performance such as logging my OTJ hours was behind.

## Evaluation and Analysis

While my independence, professional performance, and networking improved, my lack of routine and time management negatively impacted my university work. It's also altered my thinking in regards to assuming that university and my apprenticeship work were two separate things, whereas I came to realise was that they both come hand in hand together. So much focus went into focusing on my job role as a change management coordinator rather than trying to balance both. Although I earned my promotion to my current role as a deployment manager, I felt disappointed with my university performance.

## Conclusion

From this experience, I became more independent in myself and I understand what having an unorganised lifestyle looks like. This experience has taught me the importance of setting boundaries and taking care of my well-being. On a personal note, I invested in books and online material to become more financially literate which helped me handle my bills better. I also came out of my comfort zone by attend networking events as well as meeting other apprentices across different industries which has broadened my network. In conclusion, going through this personal journey of learning how crucial it is to look after my well-being during my apprenticeship journey is crucial in achieving success in both university and project work.

### Action Plan

The biggest priority will be focusing on my personal well-being. Maintaining a healthy routine which includes regular exercise, consistent sleep and balanced nutrition is crucial and with this in place, my body is in a better place to handle higher workloads and stressful moments. As mentioned in my Risk Management table, I included time management in my inherent risks. Focusing on mitigating these risks also ties in with managing workload and stress. I've so far implemented timeblocking to delegate my daily tasks much better. Creating the project plan and gaant chart has help me have a direct path in knowing what I want to achieve in my degree apprenticeship. To continue with this momentum, I will make it paramount to regularly review my diagrams and communicate my progress to my stakeholders.

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